

Yuga cycle

A **yuga cycle** (a.k.a. *chatur yuga*, *maha yuga*, etc.) is a cyclic age (epoch) in Hindu cosmology. Each cycle lasts for 4,320,000 years (12,000 divine years^[a]) and repeats four *yugas* (world ages): *Krita (Satya) Yuga*, *Treta Yuga*, *Dvapara Yuga*, and *Kali Yuga*.^[4]

As a *yuga* cycle progresses through the four *yugas*, each *yuga*'s length and humanity's general moral and physical state within each *yuga* decrease by one-fourth. *Kali Yuga*, which lasts for 432,000 years, is believed to have started in 3102 BCE.^{[5][6]} Near the end of *Kali Yuga*, when virtues are at their worst, a cataclysm and a reestablishment of *dharma* occur to usher in the next cycle's *Krita (Satya) Yuga*, prophesied to occur by *Kalki*.^[7]

There are 71 *yuga* cycles in a *manvantara* (age of *Manu*) and 1,000 *yuga* cycles in a *kalpa* (day of *Brahma*).^[6]

Lexicology

A *yuga* cycle has several names.

Age or *Yuga* (Sanskrit: युग, lit. 'an age of the gods'):

"Age" and "*Yuga*", sometimes with reverential capitalization, commonly denote a "*catur-yuga*", a cycle of four world ages, unless expressly limited by the name of one of its minor ages (e.g. *Kali Yuga*).^{[8][b]} Its archaic spelling is *yug*, with other forms of *yugam*, *yugānām*, and *yuge*, derived from *yuj* (Sanskrit: युज्, lit. 'to join or yoke'), believed derived from **yeug-* (Proto-Indo-European: lit. 'to join or unite').^[11]

Chatur Yuga (Sanskrit: चतुर्युग, romanized: *caturyuga*, *catur-yuga*, *chaturyuga*, or *chatur-yuga*, lit. 'catur means four; a set of the four ages'):^[12]

A cyclic age encompassing the four *yuga* ages^{[6][13]} as defined in Hindu texts: *Surya Siddhanta*,^[8] *Manusmriti*,^[14] and *Bhagavata Purana*.^[15]

Daiva Yuga (Sanskrit: दैवयुग, romanized: *daivayuga* or *daiva-yuga*, lit. 'a divine or celestial age; an age of the gods'),^[16]

Deva Yuga (Sanskrit: देवयुग, romanized: *devayuga* or *deva-yuga*, lit. 'an age of the gods'),^[17]

Divya Yuga (Sanskrit: दिव्य युग, romanized: *divyayuga* or *divya-yuga*, lit. 'a divine or celestial age'):

A cyclic age of the divine, celestial, or gods (*Devas*) encompassing the four *yuga* ages (a.k.a. "human ages" or "world ages"). The Hindu texts give a length of 12,000 divine years, where a divine year lasts for 360 solar (human) years.^{[5][6]}

Maha Yuga (Sanskrit: महायुग, romanized: *mahāyuga* or *mahā-yuga*, lit. 'a great age'):^[18]

A greater cyclic age encompassing the smaller four *yuga* ages.^{[6][19]}

Yuga cycle (Sanskrit: युग, lit. 'age') + (English: cycle):

A cyclic age encompassing the four *yuga* ages.

It is theorized that the concept of the four *yugas* originated some time after the compilation of the four Vedas, but prior to the rest of the Hindu texts, based on the concept's absence in the former writings. It is believed that the four *yugas*—*Krita* (*Satya*), *Treta*, *Dvapara*, and *Kali*—are named after throws of an Indian game of long dice, marked with 4-3-2-1 respectively.^[5] A dice game is described in the Rigveda, Atharvaveda, Upanishads, Ramayana, Mahabharata, and Puranas, while the four *yugas* are described after the four Vedas with no mention of a correlation to dice.^{[13][20]} A complete description of the four *yugas* and their characteristics are in the Vishnu Smriti (ch. 20),^[21] Mahabharata (e.g. Vanaparva 149, 183), Manusmriti (I.81–86), and Puranas (e.g. Brahma, ch. 122–123; Matsya, ch. 142–143; Naradiya, Purvardha, ch. 41).^[22] The four *yugas* are also described in the Bhagavata Purana (3.11.18–20).

Duration and structure

Hindu texts describe four *yugas* (world ages) in a *yuga* cycle—*Krita* (*Satya*) *Yuga*, *Treta* *Yuga*, *Dvapara* *Yuga*, and *Kali* *Yuga*—where, starting in order from the first age, each *yuga*'s length decreases according to a ratio of 4:3:2:1. Each *yuga* is described as having a main period (a.k.a. *yuga* proper) preceded by its *yuga-sandhyā* (dawn) and followed by its *yuga-sandhyāṃśa* (dusk), where each twilight (dawn/dusk) lasts for one-tenth (10%) of its main period. Lengths are given in divine years (years of the gods), each lasting for 360 solar (human) years.^{[4][5][6]}

Each *yuga* cycle lasts for 4,320,000 years (12,000 divine years) with its four *yugas*: *Krita* (*Satya*) *Yuga* for 1,728,000 (4,800 divine) years, *Treta* *Yuga* for 1,296,000 (3,600 divine) years, *Dvapara* *Yuga* for 864,000 (2,400 divine) years, and *Kali* *Yuga* for 432,000 (1,200 divine) years.^{[4][5][6]}

Structure of a *yuga* cycle

Yuga	Part	Divine years	Solar years
<i>Krita</i> (<i>Satya</i>)	<i>Krita-yuga-sandhya</i> (dawn)	400	144,000
	<i>Krita-yuga</i> (proper)	4,000	1,440,000
	<i>Krita-yuga-sandhyamsa</i> (dusk)	400	144,000
<i>Treta</i>	<i>Treta-yuga-sandhya</i> (dawn)	300	108,000
	<i>Treta-yuga</i> (proper)	3,000	1,080,000
	<i>Treta-yuga-sandhyamsa</i> (dusk)	300	108,000
<i>Dvapara</i>	<i>Dvapara-yuga-sandhya</i> (dawn)	200	72,000
	<i>Dvapara-yuga</i> (proper)	2,000	720,000
	<i>Dvapara-yuga-sandhyamsa</i> (dusk)	200	72,000
<i>Kali</i>	<i>Kali-yuga-sandhya</i> (dawn)	100	36,000
	<i>Kali-yuga</i> (proper)	1,000	360,000
	<i>Kali-yuga-sandhyamsa</i> (dusk)	100	36,000
Total		12,000	4,320,000

The current cycle's four *yugas* have the following dates based on *Kali Yuga*, the fourth and present age, starting in 3102 BCE:^{[6][13][23]}

Yuga cycle

Yuga	Start (– End)	Length
<i>Krita</i> (<i>Satya</i>)	3,891,102 BCE	1,728,000 (4,800)
<i>Treta</i>	2,163,102 BCE	1,296,000 (3,600)
<i>Dvapara</i>	867,102 BCE	864,000 (2,400)
<i>Kali</i> *	3102 BCE – 428,899 CE	432,000 (1,200)
Years: 4,320,000 solar (12,000 divine)		

(*) Current.

^{[c][23][24]}

Mahabharata, Book 12 (*Shanti Parva*), Ch. 231:^{[25][d]}

(17) A year (of men) is equal to a day and night of the gods ... (19) I shall, in their order, tell you the number of years that are for different purposes calculated differently, in the Krita, the Treta, the Dwapara, and the Kali yugas. (20) Four thousand celestial years is the duration of the first or Krita age. The morning of that cycle consists of four hundred years and its evening is of four hundred years. (21) Regarding the other cycles, the duration of each gradually decreases by a quarter in respect of both the principal period with the minor portion and the conjoining portion itself. (29) The learned say that these twelve thousand celestial years form what is called a cycle ...

(67) A year is a day and a night of the gods ... (68) But hear now the brief (description of) the duration of a night and a day of Brahman [(Brahma)] and of the several ages (of the world, yuga) according to their order. (69) They declare that the Krita age (consists of) four thousand years (of the gods); the twilight preceding it consists of as many hundreds, and the twilight following it of the same number. (70) In the other three ages with their twilights preceding and following, the thousands and hundreds are diminished by one (in each). (71) These twelve thousand (years) which thus have been just mentioned as the total of four (human) ages, are called one age of the gods.

(13) ... twelve months make a year. This is called a day of the gods. (14) ... Six times sixty [360] of them are a year of the gods ... (15) Twelve thousand of these divine years are denominated a Quadruple Age (caturyuga); of ten thousand times four hundred and thirty-two [4,320,000] solar years (16) Is composed that Quadruple Age, with its dawn and twilight. The difference of the Golden and the other Ages, as measured by the difference in the number of the feet of Virtue in each, is as follows : (17) The tenth part of an Age, multiplied successively by four, three, two, and one, gives the length of the Golden and the other Ages, in order : the sixth part of each belongs to its dawn and twilight.

Greater cycles

There are 71 *yuga* cycles (306,720,000 years) in a *manvantara*, a period ruled by Manu, who is the progenitor of mankind.^[28] There are 1,000 *yuga* cycles (4,320,000,000 years) in a *kalpa*, a period that is a day (12-hour day proper) of Brahma, who is the creator of the planets and first living entities. There are 14 *manvantaras* (4,294,080,000 years) in a *kalpa* with a remainder of 25,920,000 years assigned to 15 *manvantara-sandhyas* (junctures), each the length of a *Satya Yuga* (1,728,000 years). A *kalpa* is followed by a *pralaya* (night or partial dissolution) of equal length forming a full day (24-hour day). A *maha-kalpa* (life of Brahma) lasts for 100 360-day years of Brahma, which lasts for 72,000,000 *yuga* cycles (311.04 trillion years) and is followed by a *maha-pralaya* (full dissolution) of equal length.^[6]

We are currently halfway through Brahma's life (*maha-kalpa*):^{[6][29][30][31]}

- 51st year of 100 (2nd half or *parardha*)
- 1st month of 12
- 1st *kalpa* (*Shveta-Varaha Kalpa*) of 30
- 7th *manvantara* (Vaivasvatha Manu) of 14
- 28th *chatur-yuga* (a.k.a. *yuga* cycle) of 71
- 4th *yuga* (*Kali Yuga*) of 4

Yuga dates are used in an *ashloka*, which is read out at the beginning of Hindu rites to specify the elapsed time in Brahma's life. For example, an ashloka in 2007 CE of the Gregorian calendar might include the lines:^{[32][e]}

5109 of *Kalyugi* year of the 28th *Chaturyugee* of the 7th *Manvantara* on the first day of the 51st year of the 2nd *Brahma* [(2nd half of Brahma's life)].

Virtues

According to the *Manusmriti*, the virtue (*dharma*) of human beings varies across the four *yugas* (ages). The text states:

तपः परं कृतयुगे त्रेतायां ज्ञानमुच्यते ।
द्वापरे यज्ञमेवाहुर्दानमेकं कलौ युगे ॥

tapah param kṛtayuge tretāyām jñānamucyate

dvāpare yajñamevāhurdānamekaṃ kalau yuge

In the *Krita Yuga*, the virtue is **austerity** (*tapas*); in the *Treta Yuga*, it is **knowledge** (*jnana*); in the *Dvapara Yuga*, it is **sacrifice** (*yajna*); and in the *Kali Yuga*, it is **charity** (*dāna*).^[33]

Avatars

Ganesha

Ganesha avatars are described as coming during specific *yugas*.^{[34][35][36]}

Vishnu

The *Puranas* describe *Vishnu avatars* that come during specific *yugas*, but may not occur in every *yuga* cycle.

Vamana appears at the beginning of *Treta Yuga*. According to *Vayu Purana*, Vamana's 3rd appearance was in the 7th *Treta Yuga*.^{[37][38]}

Rama appears during the *Treta Yuga*.^[39] According to *Vayu Purana* and *Matsya Purana*, Rama appeared in the 24th *yuga* cycle.^[40] According to *Padma Purana*, Rama also appeared in the 27th *yuga* cycle of the 6th (previous) *manvantara*.^[41]

Vyasa

Vyasa is attributed as the compiler of the four *Vedas*, *Mahabharata*, and *Puranas*. According to the *Vishnu Purana*, *Kurma Purana*, and *Shiva Purana*, a different Vyasa comes at the end of each *Dvapara Yuga* to write down *veda* (knowledge) to guide humans in the degraded age of *Kali Yuga*.^{[42][43][44]}

Modern theories

Breaking from the long duration of a *yuga* cycle, new theories have emerged regarding the length, number, and order of the *yugas*.

Sri Yukteswar Giri

Swami Sri Yukteswar Giri (1855–1936) proposed a *yuga* cycle of 24,000 years in the introduction of his book *The Holy Science* (1894).^[45]

He claimed the understanding that *Kali Yuga* lasts for 432,000 years was a mistake, which he traced back to Raja Parikshit, just after the descending *Dvapara Yuga* ended (c. 3101 BCE) and all the wise men of his court retired to the Himalaya Mountains. With no one left to correctly calculate the ages, *Kali Yuga* never officially started. After 499 CE, in ascending *Dvapara Yuga*, when the intellect of men began to develop, but not fully, they noticed mistakes and attempted to correct them by converting what they thought to be divine years to human years (1:360 ratio). Yukteswar's *yuga* lengths for *Satya*, *Treta*, *Dvapara*, and *Kali* are respectively 4,800, 3,600, 2,400, and 1,200 "human" years (12,000 years total).^{[46][47]}

He accepted the four *yugas* and their 4:3:2:1 length and *dharma* proportions, but his *yuga* cycle contained eight *yugas*, the original descending set of the four *yugas* followed by an ascending (reversed) set, where he called each set a "*Daiva Yuga*" or "Electric Couple". His *yuga* cycle lasts for 24,000 years, which he believed equals one precession of the equinoxes (traditionally 25,920 years; 1,920 years difference). He states that the world entered the Pisces-Virgo Age in 499 CE ("cycle bottom"), and that the current age of ascending *Dvapara Yuga* started in 1699 CE around the time of scientific discoveries and advancements such as electricity.^{[48][47]}

He explained that in a 24,000-year *yuga* cycle, the Sun completes one orbit around some dual star, becoming nearer and farther to a galactic center, which the pair orbit in a longer period. He called this galactic center Vishnunabhi (Vishnu's Navel), where Brahma regulates *dharma* or, as Yukteswar defined it, mental virtue. *Dharma* is lowest when farthest from Brahma at the descending-ascending intersection ("cycle-bottom"), where the opposite occurs at the "cycle-top" when nearest. At *dharma*'s lowest (499 CE), human intellect cannot comprehend anything beyond the gross material world.^{[49][50]}

Sri Yukteswar's *yuga* cycle

<i>Yuga</i>	Start (– End)	Length
Descending (12,000 years)		
<i>Krita (Satya)</i>	11,501 BCE	4,800
<i>Treta</i>	6701 BCE	3,600
<i>Dvapara</i>	3101 BCE	2,400
<i>Kali</i>	701 BCE	1,200
Ascending (12,000 years)		
<i>Kali</i>	499 CE	1,200
<i>Dvapara*</i>	1699 CE	2,400
<i>Treta</i>	4099 CE	3,600
<i>Krita (Satya)</i>	7699–12,499 CE	4,800
Years: 24,000		

(*) Current.

[e]

Joscelyn Godwin states that Yukteswar believed the traditional chronology of the *yugas* wrong and rigged for political reasons, but that Yukteswar may have had political reasons of his own, evident in a police report printed in *Atlantis and the Cycles of Time*, which links Yukteswar to a secret anti-colonial movement called *Yugantar*, meaning "new age" or "transition of an epoch".^[51]

Godwin claims the *Jain time cycle* and the *European myth of progress* influenced Yukteswar, whose theory only recently became prominent outside India. Humanity in an upward cycle is contrary to traditional ideas. Godwin points out many philosophies and religions that started during a time when "man could not see beyond the gross material world" (701 BCE – 1699 CE). Only *materialists* and *atheists* would welcome the post-1700 age as an improvement.^[52]

John Major Jenkins, who adjusted ascending *Kali Yuga* from 499 CE to 2012 in his version, criticizes Yukteswar as wanting the "cycle-bottom" to correspond to his education, beliefs, and historical understanding. Technology has thrust us deeper into material dependency and spiritual darkness.^[53]

René Guénon

René Guénon (1886–1951) proposed a *yuga* cycle of 64,800 years in his 1931 French article, which was later translated in the book *Traditional Forms & Cosmic Cycles* (2001).^[54]

Guénon accepted the doctrine of the four *yugas*, the 4:3:2:1 *yuga* length proportions, and *Kali Yuga* as the present age. He couldn't accept the extremely large lengths and felt they were encoded with additional zeros to mislead those who might use it to predict the future. He reduced a *yuga* cycle from 4,320,000 to 4,320 years (1,728 + 1,296 + 864 + 432), but he felt this was too short for humanity's history.^[55]

In looking for a multiplier, he worked backwards from the *precession of the equinoxes* (traditionally 25,920 years; 360 72-year degrees). Using 25,920 and 72, he calculated the sub-multiplier to be 4,320 years ($72 \times 60 = 4,320$; $4,320 \times 6 = 25,920$). In noticing the "great year" of the Persians (~12,000) and Greeks (~13,000) as almost half the precession, he concluded a "great year" must be 12,960 years ($4,320 \times 3$). In trying to find the whole number of "great years" in a *manvantara* or reign of *Vaivasvata Manu*, he

found the reign of Xisuthros of the Chaldeans to be set to 64,800 years ($12,960 \times 5$), someone he thought to be the same Manu. Guénon felt 64,800 years was a more plausible length that may line up with humanity's history. He calculated a 64,800 *manvantara* divided into a 4,320 "encoded" *yuga* cycle gave a multiplier of 15 (5 "great years"). Using 15 as the multiplier, he "decoded" a 5-"great year" *yuga* cycle as having the following *yuga* lengths:^{[54][56]}

- *Satya*: 25,920 (4 ratio or $2 \times$ "great year"; $15 \times 1,728$)
- *Treta*: 19,440 (3 ratio or $1.5 \times$ "great year"; $15 \times 1,296$)
- *Dvapara*: 12,960 (2 ratio or $1 \times$ "great year"; 15×864)
- *Kali*: 6,480 (1 ratio or $0.5 \times$ "great year"; 15×432)

Guénon did not give a start date for *Kali Yuga*, but instead left clues in his description of the cataclysmic destruction of the Atlantean civilization. His commentator, Jean Robin, in an early 1980s publication, claimed to have decoded this description and calculated that *Kali Yuga* lasted from 4481 BCE to 1999 CE (2000 CE excluding year 0).^[57] In *Les Quatre Âges de L'Humanité* (*The Four Ages of Humanity*), a book written in 1949 by Gaston Georgel, this same end date of 1999 CE was calculated; although, in his 1983 book titled *Le Cycle Judéo-Chrétien* (*The Judeo-Christian Cycle*), he later argued to shift the cycle forward by 31 years to end in 2030 CE.^[58]

René Guénon's *yuga* cycle

<i>Yuga</i>	Start (– End)	Length
<i>Krita (Satya)</i>	62,801 BCE	25,920
<i>Treta</i>	36,881 BCE	19,440
<i>Dvapara</i>	17,441 BCE	12,960
<i>Kali</i>	4481 BCE – 1999 CE	6,480
Years: 64,800		

Current: *Krita Yuga* [1999–27,919 CE], next cycle. [e][f]

Alain Daniélou

Alain Daniélou (1907–1994) proposed a *yuga* cycle of 60,487 years in his book *While the Gods Play: Shaiva Oracles and Predictions on the Cycles of History and the Destiny of Mankind* (1985).^[59]

Daniélou and René Guénon had some correspondence where they both couldn't accept the extremely large lengths found in the Puranas. Daniélou mostly cited Linga Purana and his calculations are based on a 4,320,000-year *yuga* cycle containing (his calculation of $1000 \div 14$) 71.42 *manvantaras*, each containing four *yugas* [4:3:2:1 proportions]. He pegged 3102 BCE as the start of *Kali Yuga* and placed it after the dawn (*yuga-sandhya*). He claimed his dates are accurate to within 50 years, and that the *yuga* cycle started with a great flood and appearance of Cro-Magnon man, and will end with a catastrophe wiping out mankind.^[60]

Alain Daniélou's *yuga* cycle

Yuga	Start (– End)	Length
<i>Krita (Satya)</i>	58,042 BCE	24,195
<i>Treta</i>	33,848 BCE	18,146
<i>Dvapara</i>	15,703 BCE	12,097
<i>Kali*</i>	3606 BCE – 2442 CE	6,048.72
Years: 60,487		

(*) Current.

[e][61]

Joscelyn Godwin found that Daniélou's misunderstanding rests solely on a bad translation of *Linga Purana* 1.4.7.^[62]

Hindu astronomy

In the early texts of Hindu astronomy such as *Surya Siddhanta*, the length of a *yuga* cycle is used to specify the orbital period of heavenly bodies. Instead of specifying the period of a single orbit of a heavenly body around the Earth, the number of orbits of a heavenly body in a *yuga* cycle is specified.

Surya Siddhanta, Ch. 1:^[63]

(29) In an Age (*yuga*), the revolutions of the sun, Mercury, and Venus, and of the conjunctions (*shighra*) of Mars, Saturn, and Jupiter, moving eastward, are four million, three hundred and twenty thousand; (30) Of the moon, fifty-seven million, seven hundred and fifty-three thousand, three hundred and thirty-six; of Mars, two million, two hundred and ninety-six thousand, eight hundred and thirty-two; (31) Of Mercury's conjunction (*shighra*), seventeen million, nine hundred and thirty-seven thousand, and sixty; of Jupiter, three hundred and sixty-four thousand, two hundred and twenty; (32) Of Venus's conjunction (*shighra*), seven million, twenty-two thousand, three hundred and seventy-six; of Saturn, one hundred and forty-six thousand, five hundred and sixty-eight; (33) Of the moon's apsis (*ucca*), in an Age, four hundred and eighty-eight thousand, two hundred and three; of its node (*pata*), in the contrary direction, two hundred and thirty-two thousand, two hundred and thirty-eight; (34) Of the asterisms, one billion, five hundred and eighty-two million, two hundred and thirty-seven thousand, eight hundred and twenty-eight....

The orbital period of heavenly bodies can be derived from the above numbers provided the starting point of a *yuga* cycle is known. According to Burgess, the *Surya Siddhanta* fixes the starting point of *Kali Yuga* as:

The instant at which the Age is made to commence is midnight on the meridian of Ujjayini, at the end of the 588,465th and beginning of the 588,466th day (civil reckoning) of the Julian Period, or between the 17th and 18th of February 1612 J.P., or 3102 B.C.^[64]

Based on this starting point, Ebenezer Burgess calculates the following planetary orbital periods:

Comparative table of sidereal revolutions of the planets (geocentric)^[65]

Planet	<i>Surya Siddhanta</i>		Modern
	Revolutions in a <i>yuga</i> cycle	Revolution length ^[9] (day hr min sec)	Orbital period (day hr min sec)
Sun	4,320,000	365 6 12 36.6	365 6 9 10.8
Mercury	17,937,060	87 23 16 22.3	87 23 15 43.9
Venus	7,022,376	224 16 45 56.2	224 16 49 8.0
Mars	2,296,832	686 23 56 23.5	686 23 30 41.4
Jupiter	364,220	4,332 7 41 44.4	4,332 14 2 8.6
Saturn	146,568	10,765 18 33 13.6	10,759 5 16 32.2
Moon (sidereal)	57,753,336	27 7 43 12.6	27 7 43 11.4
Moon (synodic)	53,433,336	29 12 44 2.8	29 12 44 2.9

Other cultures

According to Robert Bolton, there is a universal belief in many traditions that the world started in a perfect state, when nature and the supernatural were still in harmony with all things in their fullest degree of perfection possible, which was followed by an unpreventable constant deterioration of the world through the ages.^[66]

In the *Works and Days* (lines 109–201; c. 700 BCE), considered the earliest European writing about human ages, the Greek poet Hesiod describes five ages (Golden, Silver, Bronze, Heroic, and Iron Ages), where the Heroic Age was added, according to Godwin, as a compromise with Greek history when the Trojan War and its heroes loomed so large.^[67] Bolton explains that the men of the Golden Age lived like gods without sorrow, toil, grief, and old age, while the men of the Iron Age ("the race of iron") never rest from labor and sorrow, are degenerated without shame, morality, and righteous indignation, and have short lives with frequent deaths at night, where even a new-born baby shows signs of old age, only to end when Zeus destroys it all.^[68]

In the *Statesman* (c. 399 – c. 347 BCE), the Athenian philosopher Plato describes time as an indefinite cycle of two 36,000-year halves: (1) the world's unmaking descent into chaos and destruction; (2) the world's remaking by its creator into a renewed state.^[69] In the *Cratylus* (397e), Plato recounts the golden race of men who came first, who were noble and good *daemons* (godlike guides) upon the earth.

In the *Metamorphoses* (I, 89–150; c. 8 BCE), the Roman poet Ovid describes four ages (Golden, Silver, Bronze, and Iron Ages), excluding Hesiod's Heroic Age, as a downward curve with the present time as the nadir of misery and immorality, according to Godwin, affecting both human life and the after-death state, where deaths in the first two ages became immortal, watchful spirits that benefited the human race, deaths in the third age went to Hades (Greek god of the underworld), and deaths in the fourth age had an unknown fate.^[70]

Joscelyn Godwin posits that it is probably from Hindu tradition that knowledge of the ages reached the Greeks and other Indo-European peoples.^[70] Godwin adds that the number 432,000 (*Kali Yuga*'s duration) occurring in four widely separated cultures (Hindu, Chaldean, Chinese, and Icelandic) has long

been noticed.^[71]

In *Symbolic Astronomy*, Mackenzie Muileboom points out that the numbers 432, 84, 24, and 10 often appear together in these mythologies: e.g. according to Berossus, the 10 pre-flood Kings ruled for 432000 years; in Jainism, the 22nd tirthankara (out of 24) is said to have lived 84000 years ago; the *Iliad* and *Odyssey* recount a 10 year war and a 10 year voyage and are divided into 24 books each; Mount Meru is said to be 84000 yojanas high, has 9 or 10 levels (as depicted at Borobudur, whose six square levels have 432 Buddha statues), and represents the Earth's axis (whose tilt varies between 22 and 24 degrees, causing the "four seasons", the equinoxes and solstices, like the 4 yugas), which form a mathematical sequence, since 431 is the 83rd prime number, 83 is the 23rd prime number, and 23 is the 9th prime number.^[72]

See also

- Hindu eschatology
- Hindu units of time
 - Kalpa (day of Brahma)
 - Manvantara (age of Manu)
 - Pralaya (period of dissolution)
 - Yuga Cycle (four yuga ages): Satya (Krita), Treta, Dvapara, and Kali
- Itihasa (Hindu Tradition)
- List of numbers in Hindu scriptures
- Vedic-Puranic chronology



Explanatory notes

- a. 360 solar years constitute a divine year. This is as per the following belief system: The gods are believed to reside in the north celestial sphere.^[1] Due to the axial tilt of the earth, the Sun is overhead the northern hemisphere during the period between the vernal and the autumnal equinox. This period is designated the daytime of the gods. Conversely, the Sun is overhead the southern hemisphere during the period between the autumnal and the vernal equinox. This period is designated the "nighttime of the gods". Put together, an entire tropical solar year is designated the "day of the gods".^[2] 360 such "days of the gods" make a divine year.^[3]
- b. The general word "*yuga*" is sometimes used instead of the more specific word "*catur-yuga*". A *kalpa* is described as lasting 1,000 *catur-yuga* in Bhagavata Purana 12.4.2 ("*catur-yuga*")^[9] and Bhagavad Gita 8.17 ("*yuga*").^[10]
- c. Each *Kali-yuga-sandhi* lasts for 36,000 solar (100 divine) years:
 - * *Sandhya*: 3102 BCE – 32,899 CE
 - * *Sandhyamsa*: 392,899–428,899 CE
- d. Chapter 224 (CCXXIV) in some sources: *Mahabharata* 12.224.
- e. A common error exists in calculating from 1 BCE to 1 CE as 2 years instead of 1. There is no year zero.
- f. René Guénon's *yuga* cycle table: the calculated dates are based on the 1949 publication by Gaston Georgel, *Les Quatre Âges de L'Humanité* (*The Four Ages of Humanity*), and an early 1980s publication by Jean Robin.

g. Calculated in mean solar time.

References

1. Burgess 1935, pp. 285, 286, chapter XII verses 34-36.
2. Burgess 1935, pp. 288, 289, chapter XII verse 45-51: The Surya Siddhanta identifies the vernal equinox with the First Point of Aries and hence does not distinguish between the sidereal and tropical year.
3. Burgess 1935, pp. 8, 9, chapter I verse 13,14.
4. Godwin, Joscelyn (2011). *Atlantis and the Cycles of Time: Prophecies, Traditions, and Occult Revelations* (<https://books.google.com/books?id=H14oDwAAQBAJ>). Inner Traditions. pp. 300–301. ISBN 9781594778575.
5. Merriam-Webster (1999). "Merriam-Webster's Encyclopedia of World Religions" (https://archive.org/details/isbn_9780877790440). In Doniger, Wendy; Hawley, John Stratton (eds.). *Merriam-Webster*. Merriam-Webster, Incorporated. pp. 445 (Hinduism) (https://archive.org/details/isbn_9780877790440/page/445/mode/1up), 1159 (Yuga) (https://archive.org/details/isbn_9780877790440/page/1159/mode/1up). ISBN 0877790442. "

* HINDUISM: Myths of time and eternity: ... Each yuga is preceded by an intermediate "dawn" and "dusk". The Krita yuga lasts 4,000 god-years, with a dawn and dusk of 400 god-years each, or a total of 4,800 god-years; Treta a total of 3,600 god-years; Dvapara 2,400 god-years; and Kali (the current yuga) 1,200 god-years. A *mahayuga* thus lasts 12,000 god-years ... Since each god-year lasts 360 human years, a *mahayuga* is 4,320,000 years long in human time. Two thousand *mahayugas* form one kalpa (eon) [and pralaya], which is itself but one day in the life of Brahma, whose full life lasts 100 years; the present is the midpoint of his life. Each kalpa is followed by an equally long period of abeyance (*pralaya*), in which the universe is asleep. Seemingly the universe will come to an end at the end of Brahma's life, but Brahmas too are innumerable, and a new universe is reborn with each new Brahma.

* YUGA: each *yuga* is progressively shorter than the preceding one, corresponding to a decline in the moral and physical state of humanity. Four such yugas (called ... after throws of an Indian game of dice) make up a mahayuga ("great yuga") ... The first yuga (Krita) was an age of perfection, lasting 1,728,000 years. The fourth and most degenerate yuga (Kali) began in 3102 BCE and will last 432,000 years. At the close of the Kali yuga, the world will be destroyed by fire and flood, to be re-created as the cycle resumes. In a partially competing vision of time, Vishnu's 10th and final AVATAR, KALKI, is described as bringing the present cosmic cycle to a close by destroying the evil forces that rule the Kali yuga and ushering in an immediate return to the idyllic Krita yuga."

6. Gupta, S. V. (2010). "Ch. 1.2.4 Time Measurements" (<https://books.google.com/books?id=pHiKycrLmEQC&pg=PA7>). In Hull, Robert; Osgood, Richard M. Jr.; Parisi, Jurgen; Warlimont, Hans (eds.). *Units of Measurement: Past, Present and Future. International System of Units*. Springer Series in Materials Science: 122. Springer. pp. 6–8. ISBN 9783642007378.
 "Paraphrased: Deva day equals solar year. Deva lifespan (36,000 solar years) equals 100 360-day years, each 12 months. Mahayuga equals 12,000 Deva (divine) years (4,320,000 solar years), and is divided into 10 charnas consisting of four Yugas: Satya Yuga (4 charnas of 1,728,000 solar years), Treta Yuga (3 charnas of 1,296,000 solar years), Dvapara Yuga (2 charnas of 864,000 solar years), and Kali Yuga (1 charna of 432,000 solar years). Manvantara equals 71 Mahayugas (306,720,000 solar years). Kalpa (day of Brahma) equals an Adi Sandhya, 14 Manvantaras, and 14 Sandhya Kalas, where 1st Manvantara preceded by Adi Sandhya and each Manvantara followed by Sandhya Kala, each Sandhya lasting same duration as Satya yuga (1,728,000 solar years), during which the entire earth is submerged in water. Day of Brahma equals 1,000 Mahayugas, the same length for a night of Brahma (Bhagavad-gita 8.17). Brahma lifespan (311.04 trillion solar years) equals 100 360-day years, each 12 months. Parardha is 50 Brahma years and we are in the 2nd half of his life. After 100 years of Brahma, the universe starts with a new Brahma. We are currently in the 28th Kali yuga of the first day of the 51st year of the second Parardha in the reign of the 7th (Vaivasvata) Manu. This is the 51st year of the present Brahma and so about 155 trillion years have elapsed. The current Kali Yuga (Iron Age) began at midnight on 17/18 February 3102 BC in the proleptic Julian calendar."
7. Merriam-Webster 1999, p. 629 (Kalki): At the end of the present Kali age, when virtue and religion have disappeared into CHAOS and the world is ruled by unjust men, Kalki will appear to destroy the wicked and usher in a new age. ... According to some myths, Kalki's horse will stamp the earth with its right foot, causing the tortoise that supports the world to drop into the deep. Then Kalki will restore the earth to its initial purity.
8. Burgess 1935, p. 9: The period of 4,320,000 years is ordinarily styled Great Age (*mahayuga*), or, as above in two instances [1.15–16], Quadruple Age (*caturyuga*). In the Surya-Siddhanta, however, the former term is not once found, and the latter occurs only in these verses; elsewhere, age (*yuga*) alone is employed to denote it, and always denotes it, unless expressly limited by the name of the Golden (*krta*) Age.
9. "Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam (Bhāgavata Purāṇa) 12.4.2" (<https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/12/4/2/>). *Bhaktivedanta Vedabase*. Retrieved 2020-05-10. "
 catur-yuga-sahasraṁ tu brahmaṇo dinam ucyate |
 sa kalpo yatra manavaś caturdaśa viśāṁ-pate || 2 ||
 (2) One thousand cycles of four ages [*catur-yuga*] constitute a single day of Brahmā, known as a kalpa. In that period, O King, fourteen Manus come and go."
10. "Bhagavad-gītā As It Is 8.17" (<https://vedabase.io/en/library/bg/8/17/>). *Bhaktivedanta Vedabase* (in Sanskrit and English). Translated by A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada. Bhaktivedanta Book Trust. 1968. LCCN 68008322 (<https://lccn.loc.gov/68008322>). Wikidata Q854700. Retrieved 2020-05-10. "
 sahasra-yuga-paryantam ahar yad brahmaṇo viduḥ |
 rātriṁ yuga-sahasrāntāṁ te 'ho-rātra-vido janāḥ || 17 ||
 (17) By human calculation, a thousand ages [*yuga*] taken together form the duration of Brahmā's one day. And such also is the duration of his night."
11. "*yeug-" (https://www.etymonline.com/word/*yeug-). *Online Etymology Dictionary*. Retrieved 2021-02-27.
12. "caturyuga" (<https://www.learn Sanskrit.cc/translate?search=caturyuga>). *Sanskrit - Dictionary*. Retrieved 2025-08-20.
13. Matchett, Freda; Yano, Michio (2003). "Part II, Ch. 6: The Puranas / Part III, Ch. 18: Calendar, Astrology, and Astronomy" (<https://books.google.com/books?id=SKBxa-MNqA8C&q=yuga&pg=PA139>). In Flood, Gavin (ed.). *The Blackwell Companion to Hinduism*. Blackwell Publishing. pp. 139–140, 390. ISBN 0631215352.

14. Bühler 1886, p. 20:
yadetat parisāṅkhyātamādāveva caturyugam ।
etad dvādaśasāhasraṁ devānāṁ yugamucyate ॥ 71 ॥
(71) These twelve thousand (years) which thus have been just mentioned as the total of four (human) ages [*caturyugam*], are called one age of the gods.
15. "Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam (Bhāgavata Purāṇa) 12.2.39" (<https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/12/2/39/>). *Bhaktivedanta Vedabase*. Retrieved 2020-05-10. "
kṛtaṁ tretā dvāparaṁ ca kaliś ceti catur-yugam ।
anena krama-yogena bhuvi prāṇiṣu vartate ॥ 39 ॥
(39) The cycle of four ages [*catur-yugam*] — Satya, Tretā, Dvāpara, and Kali — continues perpetually among living beings on this earth, repeating the same general sequence of events."
16. "daivayuga" (<https://www.learn Sanskrit.cc/translate?search=daivayuga>). *Sanskrit - Dictionary*. Retrieved 2025-08-20.
17. "devayuga" (<https://www.learn Sanskrit.cc/translate?search=devayuga>). *Sanskrit - Dictionary*. Retrieved 2025-08-20.
18. "mahAyuga" (<https://www.learn Sanskrit.cc/translate?search=mahAyuga>). *Sanskrit - Dictionary*. Retrieved 2025-08-20.
19. Godwin 2011, p. 301(a): Great Age (Mahayuga).
20. Brown, W. Norman (1964). "The Indian Games of Pachisi, Chaupar, and Chausar" (<https://www.penn.museum/sites/expedition/the-indian-games-of-pachisi-chaupar-and-chausar/>). *Expedition*. Vol. 6, no. 2. Penn Museum. p. 34. ISSN 0014-4738 (<https://search.worldcat.org/lissn/0014-4738>). "The Rig-Veda, which we may reasonably consider to have been in its present form before 1000 B.C., has references to the use of dice, and one of its hymns (Book 10, 34) is a charm to cure an inveterate and unsuccessful gambler of the compulsion to gamble that has ruined him. In the Atharva Veda, also, gambling with dice is mentioned (2.3; 4.38; 6.118; 7.52; 7.109). The Aryans of Rig-Vedic times made their dice of the vibhidaka-tree nuts, and we do not know how they used them. Evidently dicing was considered a fitting vice of kings, and in the ritualistic literature of the centuries following the Rig-Veda, say at around 800 B.C., the consecration ceremonies for a king included a game of dice—which the new king must always win—and there was a special officer to take charge of the dice. In the great epic known as the Mahabharata there are two famous instances of kings ruined by gambling."
21. Vishnu Samhita (<https://archive.org/details/in.ernet.dli.2015.213312/page/n341/mode/2up>).
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23. Godwin 2011, p. 301: The Hindu astronomers agree that the [Dvapara Yuga ended and] Kali Yuga began at midnight between February 17 and 18, 3102 BCE. Consequently [Kali Yuga] is due to end about 427,000 CE, whereupon a new Golden Age will dawn.
24. Burgess 1935, p. ix (Introduction): Calculated date of 2163102 B.C. for "the end of the Golden Age (Kṛta yuga)", the start of Treta yuga, mentioned in *Surya Siddhanta* 1.57.
25. Dutt, Manmatha Nath (1903). "Ch. 231 (CCXXXI)" (<https://archive.org/details/in.ernet.dli.2015.142208/page/n272/mode/1up>). *A Prose English Translation of The Mahabharata (Translated Literally from the Original Sanskrit text)*. Vol. Book 12 (Shanti Parva). Calcutta: Elysium Press. p. 351 (12.231.17, 19–21, 29).
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27. Burgess, Rev. Ebenezer (1935) [1860]. "Ch. 1: Of the Mean Motions of the Planets." (<https://archive.org/details/SuryaSiddhantaTranslation/page/n59/mode/1up>). In Gangooly, Phanindralal (ed.). *Translation of the Sūrya-Siddhānta: A text-book of Hindu astronomy, with notes and an appendix*. University of Calcutta. pp. 7–9 (1.13–17).
28. Merriam-Webster 1999, p. 691 (Manu): a day in the life of Brahma is divided into 14 periods called manvantaras ("Manu intervals"), each of which lasts for 306,720,000 years. In every second cycle [(new kalpa after pralaya)] the world is recreated, and a new Manu appears to become the father of the next human race. The present age is considered to be the seventh Manu cycle.
29. Burgess 1935, pp. 12–13 (1.21–24), 19.
30. Krishnamurthy, Prof. V. (2019). "Ch. 20: The Cosmic Flow of Time as per Scriptures" (<https://books.google.com/books?id=HF2NDwAAQBAJ&q=%227th+manvantara%22+%2228th%22&pg=PT407>). *Meet the Ancient Scriptures of Hinduism*. Notion Press. ISBN 9781684669387. "According to the traditional time-keeping ... Thus in Brahma's calendar the present time may be coded as his 51st year - first month - first day - 7th manvantara - 28th maha-yuga - 4th yuga or kaliyuga."
31. Godwin 2011, p. 301(b): *Vishnu Purana*, translated by the great Sanskritist Horace Hayman Wilson: One Pararddha, or half [Brahma's] existence, has expired, terminating with the Maha Kalpa called Padma. The Kalpa (or day of Brahma) termed Varaha is the first of the second period of Brahma's existence. ... The Hindu astronomers agree that the Kali Yuga began at midnight between February 17 and 18, 3102 BCE. Consequently it is due to end about 427,000 CE, whereupon a new Golden Age will dawn.
32. Gupta 2010, p. 9: At the beginning of any Hindu rite, an ashloka in Sanskrit is read out, which means that this ritual is being performed for a certain purpose (name of the purpose) by this particular person (name of the person including father's and family names) at this place (full address with country name) at this time of day (Ghadi and Pala or in hours and minutes) in 5109 of Kalyugi year (for AD 2007, or Hindu calendar year 2064 Sambat) of the 28th Chaturyugee of the 7th Manvantara on the first day of the 51st year of the 2nd Brahma [(2nd half of Brahma's life)]. This is a wonderful example of counting time from the start of the universe to the present time.
33. "Manusmriti Verse 1.86 [Variation of 'Virtue' in the four Cycles]" (<https://www.wisdomlib.org/hinduism/book/manusmriti-with-the-commentary-of-medhatithi/d/doc145529.html>). *Wisdom Library*. 8 July 2016.
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35. Grimes, John A. (1995). *Ganapati: Song of the Self* (<https://books.google.com/books?id=aogB4n95pSoC>). Albany, New York: State University of New York Press. pp. 101–104. ISBN 0-7914-2439-1. "In the *Gaṇeśa Purāṇa*, Gaṇapati is described as taking a different incarnation (*avatāra*) in each of the four cosmic ages (*yugas*). In the *kṛta yuga*, Gaṇeśa incarnates as Vināyaka (or Mahotkaṭa), the son of Kāśyapa and Aditi. ... During the *treta yuga*, Gaṇapati incarnates as Mayūreśvara, the son of Lord Śiva. ... During the *dvapara yuga*, Gaṇeśa incarnates as Gajānāna, the son of Lord Śiva. ... During the *kali yuga*, Gaṇapati incarnates as Dhūmraketu (or Śūrpakarna)."
36. Bailey, Greg (2008). *Gaṇeśapurāṇa — Part II: Kṛḍākhaṇḍa* (<https://books.google.com/books?id=fgRORuZJqsMC&pg=PA5>). Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz Verlag. pp. 5–8. ISBN 978-3-447-05472-0.
37. Part 1: 50.41 (city of Bali), 55.3, 55.7. *The Vāyu Purāṇa: Part I* (<http://archive.org/details/dli.bengal.10689.12977>). Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass. 1960. pp. 377–382.
38. Part 2: 5.133, 35.73, 35.77, 36.74–85, 37.26–32, 38.21–22, 46.29 (Bali as oblation). *The Vāyu Purāṇa: Part II* (<http://archive.org/details/dli.bengal.10689.20638>). Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass. 1960.

39. "Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam (Bhāgavata Purāṇa) 9.10.51" (<https://vedabase.io/en/library/sb/9/10/51/>). *Bhaktivedanta Vedabase*. Retrieved 2020-05-18. "Lord Rāmacandra became King during Tretā-yuga, but because of His good government, the age was like Satya-yuga. Everyone was religious and completely happy."
40. Knapp, Stephen. "Lord Rama: Fact or Fiction" (http://www.stephen-knapp.com/lord_rama_fact_or_fiction.htm). *Stephen Knapp and His Books on Vedic Culture, Eastern Philosophy and Spirituality*. Retrieved 2020-05-17. "In the Vayu Purana (70.47–48) [published by Motilal Banarsidass] there is a description of the length of Ravana's life. It explains that when Ravana's merit of penance began to decline, he met Lord Rama, the son of Dasarath, in a battle wherein Ravana and his followers were killed in the 24th Treta-yuga. ... The Matsya Purana (47/240,243–246) is another source that also gives more detail of various avatars and says Bhagawan Rama appeared at the end of the 24th Treta-yuga."
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42. Motilal Banarsidass 1960, p. 2 (fn. 1).
43. Parmeshwaranand, Swami (2001). *Encyclopaedic Dictionary of Purāṇas* (<https://books.google.com/books?id=6F0ZIBIL2ZAC>). Vol. 1 (A–C). New Delhi: Sarup & Sons. p. 169. ISBN 81-7625-226-3. "The Doubt of Vyāsa: According to the Indian tradition, the sage Vyāsa was the compiler of all the Vedas, and the composer of the *Mahābhārata* and many other works. The [*Bhāgavata Purāṇa*] repeats this tradition ..."
44. Wilson, H. H. (1940). "The Vishnu Purana: A System of Hindu Mythology and Tradition" (<https://archive.org/details/dli.ministry.24500/page/272/mode/1up>). London: John Murray. p. 272. "Twenty-eight times have the Vedas been arranged by the great Rishis in the Vaivaswata Manwantara in the Dwápara age, and consequently eight and twenty Vyásas have passed away; by whom, in their respective periods, the Veda has been divided into four."
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46. Yukteswar 1990, pp. 15–17.
47. Godwin 2011, pp. 331–332.
48. Yukteswar 1990, pp. 9–13.
49. Yukteswar 1990, pp. 7–8, 10.
50. Godwin 2011, pp. 332–333.
51. Godwin 2011, pp. 330–331.
52. Godwin 2011, pp. 330, 331, 332.
53. Godwin 2011, pp. 333–334.
54. Guénon, René (2001) [1st ed. 1970]. Fohr, Samuel D. (ed.). *Traditional Forms & Cosmic Cycles* (<https://books.google.com/books?id=XGwEg0KDrYUC&pg=PA5>) [*Formes Traditionnelles et Cycles Cosmiques*]. Translated by Fohr, Henry D. Sophia Perennis. pp. 5–8. ISBN 0900588179.
55. Godwin 2011, pp. 305–306.
56. Godwin 2011, p. 306.
57. Godwin 2011, pp. 306–307.

58. "Timeline of Cycles by René Guénon and Gaston Georgel" (<https://web.archive.org/web/20201121144321/https://sufipathoflove.com/timeline-of-cycles-by-rene-guenon-and-gaston-georgel/>). *Sufi Path of Love*. 20 April 2019. Archived from the original (<https://sufipathoflove.com/timeline-of-cycles-by-rene-guenon-and-gaston-georgel/>) on 21 November 2020. Retrieved 13 November 2020.
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61. Godwin 2011, p. 309: Daniélou said his figures are accurate to within fifty years.
62. Godwin 2011, p. 308.
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64. Burgess 1935, p. 19.
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